

The Repo Is the Onboarding Doc

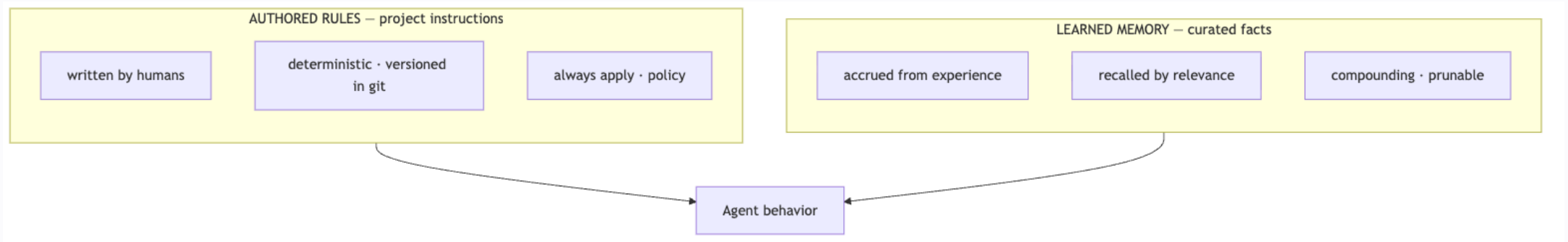
Authored rules + reusable playbooks

You don't train an AI engineer — you write down how you work.

The instinct vs the lever

- Faced with an agent that doesn't work the way the team does, the instinct is **a better model / a cleverer prompt.**
- The bigger lever is mundane: **write your conventions down where the agent reads them — every time.**

“ A new agent is only as good as the manual you hand it. The repo *is* that manual. ”



Two sources of behavior

Authored rules (policy you write) and **learned memory** (facts it accrues). Both shape behavior — governed differently.

Authored rules – the constitution

A project-instructions file the agent reads on **every task**:

- **Deterministic** – same input, same policy.
- **Versioned in git** – reviewed like code.
- **Always applied** – not recalled by chance.

What goes in rules

- Conventions, guardrails, where-things-live
- Do / don't, the verification bar, the coordination protocol

“ **Policy – not facts.**

"Always branch in a worktree" is a **rule**. "This module has quirk X" is a **memory**.

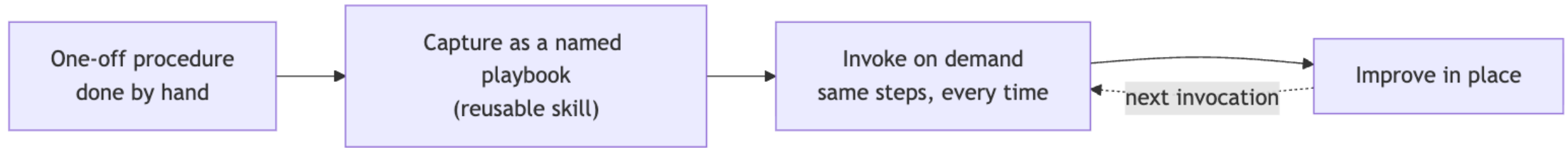
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Rules vs memory — when to use which

- **Stable policy** → rules.
- **Situational learned fact** → memory.

Getting this split right is what keeps **both** clean.

(Callback: the Tiered Agent Memory deck.)



Reusable playbooks

A procedure done **once by hand** → captured as a **named, invocable playbook** → run the **same steps every time** → improved in place.

Why playbooks

- **Repeatability** — same steps, every run.
- **No re-deriving** the procedure each time.
- The **procedure itself** is reviewed and versioned — not just its output.

“ Abstract examples: an intake/triage routine, a release checklist, a debugging protocol. ”

The compounding effect

With rules + playbooks, a **fresh agent or session is onboarded instantly** —
it **reads the manual** and the playbooks instead of relearning the shop.

What it buys

- **Consistent behavior**
- **Instant onboarding**
- **Policy-as-code**

“ *Honest caveat:* rules rot too. An over-long or stale rulebook gets **ignored** or **contradicts itself** — curate and prune it like any living doc. ”

Close

"You don't onboard an AI engineer with training. You onboard it with *writing* — and you keep the writing honest."